

Customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors: Test of a social exchange model of antecedents

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Abstract

Using a sample of 281 frontline service employees of a national retail bank, we test a social exchange model of antecedents of three dimensions of customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors suggested by prior boundary-spanning and services marketing/management literatures: external representation, internal influence, and service delivery. In support of our hypotheses, we identify fully mediated relationships from procedural, interactional, and distributive justice to external representation and internal influence via job satisfaction and organizational commitment. Our results generally support our expectation that the indirect effects of procedural justice on external representation and internal influence are stronger than the indirect effects of distributive or interactional justice on these behaviors. Also, our results reveal no significant indirect effects of procedural and distributive justice on service delivery behaviors. However, we find an unexpected direct positive path from interactional justice to service delivery behaviors. We interpret this latter finding in light of the normative value of interactional justice as a source of role modeling or managerial legitimacy.

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Over the past two decades, both academics and practitioners have asserted a “spillover” effect between employee attitudes such as justice perceptions, job satisfaction, and organizational commitment and customers’ satisfaction and service quality perceptions (cf. Bowen, Gilliland, & Folger 1999). Empirical research has generally provided support for these assertions across service industries (cf. Bernhardt, Donthu, & Kennett 2000; Hartline & Ferrell 1996), and firms have adopted slogans such as “People-Service-Profits” to express their confidence in these linkages. Other research reveals that prosocial behaviors of frontline service employees (FSEs), including discretionary service- or customer-oriented behaviors, help to explain the spillover effects of employee attitudes on customer outcomes (Bell & Menguc 2002; Bettencourt & Brown 1997).

Despite the need for studies to better understand how and why distinct employee attitudes are related to various FSE prosocial behaviors, at least three important concerns with prior research limit our understanding. First, despite repeated calls for consideration of prosocial behaviors tailored to the unique job demands and work context of customer service employees (cf. Podsakoff, MacKenzie, Paine, & Bachrach 2000), most research on boundary-spanning service employees has only investigated prosocial behaviors such as traditional organizational citizenship behaviors (OCBs) that are equally applicable across jobs and contexts (cf. Bell & Menguc 2002). Second, although past research provides a clear indication of the relevance of applying social exchange theory to the study of relationships among employee attitudes and prosocial behaviors (cf. MacKenzie, Podsakoff, & Ahearne 1998), this research has not generally investigated the range of employee attitudes we consider. For example, studies of prosocial behavior antecedents have often not included distributive, procedural, and interactional justice perceptions simultaneously or have not included both job satisfaction and organizational commitment with justice per-

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ceptions (cf. Netemeyer, Boles, McKee, & McMurrian 1997; Moorman, Blakely, & Niehoff 1998). Third, past research has not provided a thorough theoretical or empirical consideration of how distinct FSE attitudes may be *differentially* related to distinct customer-oriented behaviors. Yet, recent research demonstrates that differences among the justice dimensions may affect the strength of their relationships with customer-oriented prosocial behaviors (Masterson 2001), and differences among dimensions of customer-oriented behaviors may affect the strength of their relationships with antecedents (Bettencourt & Brown 2003).

The objective of this paper is to address these important concerns with prior research by developing a theoretical model predicting how distinct employee attitudes are related to distinct dimensions of customer-oriented behaviors, and testing this model using a sample of FSEs employed in retail banking. Specifically, the paper: (a) develops a social exchange-based model of the attitudinal antecedents of three conceptually distinct forms of customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors, (b) tests the hypothesized differential effects of three dimensions of organizational justice perceptions on the three forms of customer-oriented behaviors, and (c) investigates the extent to which these relationships are mediated by job satisfaction and organizational commitment as social exchange theory would predict.

Theoretically, the paper contributes to past literature by taking a multi-dimensional view of customer-oriented behaviors that provides deeper insight into which behaviors are most strongly related to distinct employee attitudes. The paper also offers theoretical insight into which attitude constructs are most strongly related to distinct dimensions of customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors, including consideration of the distinct effects of three theoretical dimensions of organizational justice (cf. Colquitt, Conlon, Wesson, Porter, & Ng 2001). Finally, the paper advances theoretical understanding concerning the reasons why distinct organizational justice dimensions are related to customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors by testing both direct and mediated effects of the justice constructs on customer-oriented behaviors.

Managerially, the results highlight the insufficiency of trying to establish a customer-oriented climate on the frontline of service organizations through reliance on more formal, control-oriented management practices. Rather, the results point to the necessity of developing social exchange relationships with service employees as a foundation for a customer-oriented climate. Further, the results suggest that managers should pay special attention to issues of procedural and interactional justice in seeking to develop the types of social exchange relationships that foster customer-oriented behaviors. However, the identification of fully mediated effects from procedural and distributive justice to the customer-oriented behaviors suggests that increasing perceptions of these two types of justice is simply one possible means of motivating these behaviors. Rather, the results suggest that any actions taken to improve either job satisfaction or organizational

commitment (such as increases in task variety) will also provide the desired foundation for a customer-oriented climate.

Following a brief consideration of the meaning of customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors and organizational justice, we introduce our theoretical model and develop our hypotheses. We then present an empirical field study with a sample of 281 customer service employees from an entire region of a national bank designed to test our proposed model and hypotheses. We conclude the paper with a discussion of the implications of the findings.

Conceptual background

Customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors

The services marketing/management and boundary-spanning literatures both suggest three key dimensions of customer-linking behaviors of FSEs that contribute to the development of market-driven capabilities and resources (cf. Bettencourt & Brown 2003; Bettencourt, Gwinner, & Meuter 2001). First, FSEs play an important part in representing the organization to outsiders (including customers) and enhancing the firm's image and legitimacy through their advocacy of the firm and its products and services (Aldrich & Herker 1977; Bowen & Schneider 1985). Second, the boundary-spanning position of FSEs provides them many opportunities to share information internally about evolving customer needs and possible improvements in service delivery (Aldrich & Herker 1977; Schneider & Bowen 1984; Zeithaml, Berry, & Parasuraman 1988). Third, service quality perceptions and customer satisfaction are largely dependent on FSE service delivery behaviors such as courtesy, personal attentiveness, responsiveness, and keeping promises (Aldrich & Herker 1977; Parasuraman, Zeithaml, & Berry 1988).

Drawing from this research, we investigate three types of behaviors the FSE may perform that are associated with linking the organization to its potential or actual customers (cf. Bettencourt & Brown 2003; Bettencourt et al. 2001): (1) *external representation*, being vocal advocates to outsiders of the organization's image, goods, and services (cf. Bowen & Schneider 1985), (2) *internal influence*, taking individual initiative in communications to the firm and co-workers to improve service delivery by the organization, co-workers, and oneself (cf. Schneider & Bowen 1984; Zeithaml et al. 1988), and (3) *service delivery*, serving customers in a conscientious, responsive, flexible, and courteous manner (cf. Parasuraman et al. 1988).

Included among our three dimensions are customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors (COBSBs) that are likely to be considered relatively more role-prescribed and those that are likely to be considered relatively more extra-role. For the majority of FSEs, service delivery behaviors are likely to be relatively more role-prescribed due to their frequent specification in job descriptions, training materials, and performance evaluation forms whereas external representa-

tion and internal influence behaviors are likely to be relatively more discretionary (i.e., relatively more extra-role; cf. Organ 1988a). This assertion is reinforced in the service context we study by the presence of service delivery behaviors in internal documents such as job descriptions, training materials, and performance evaluation forms. Further, recent reviews of the citizenship literature include behaviors such as external representation and internal influence among an expanded list of extra-role behaviors (cf. Podsakoff et al. 2000).

Still, we emphasize the *relative* degree to which each customer-oriented behavior is role-prescribed versus extra-role because recent research suggests that it may be more appropriate to view a variety of prosocial organizational behaviors, including traditional citizenship behaviors, as existing on a discretion continuum from entirely role-prescribed to entirely extra-role with the majority of behaviors lying somewhere between the two extremes (Tepper, Lockhart, & Hoobler 2001). Further, the role-prescribed/extra-role distinction is likely to be especially fuzzy in customer service contexts due to the difficulty in precisely specifying FSE behaviors as they interface with customers (cf. Zeithaml et al. 1988).

Organizational justice

“In organizations, justice is about the rules and social norms governing how outcomes (e.g., rewards and punishments) should be distributed, the procedures used for making such distribution decisions (as well as other types of decisions), and how people are treated interpersonally” (Folger & Cropanzano 1998, p. xiii). In keeping with a wealth of scholarly research and the definition offered by Folger and Cropanzano (1998), we consider three dimensions of organizational justice (alternatively, *fairness*): (1) *procedural justice*, the perceived fairness of the formal decision-making procedures used in an organization (cf. Lind & Tyler 1988),

(2) *interactional justice*, the perceived fairness of interpersonal treatment by managers in making decisions that impact the employee (cf. Bies & Moag 1986), and (3) *distributive justice*, the perceived fairness of outcomes or rewards that an employee receives from the firm (Folger & Cropanzano 1998; Price & Mueller 1986).

Procedural and interactional justice are often viewed by researchers as distinct aspects of the fairness of the decision process within an organization, reflecting the fairness of formal or structural decision-making procedures and the fairness of social or interpersonal aspects of decision-making, respectively (cf. Folger & Cropanzano 1998). Research on procedural justice finds that a fair decision process is characterized by formal decision-making procedures that are representative, consistent, impartial, accurate, and subject to appeal (cf. Folger & Cropanzano 1998; Leventhal, Karuza, & Fry 1980). Studies of interactional justice find that a fair decision process is characterized by a manager who makes decisions with interpersonal sensitivity (e.g., considerate, respectful, without bias) and with adequate explanation and justification (cf. Bies & Moag 1986; Folger & Cropanzano 1998).

Hypothesized relationships

Fig. 1 presents our proposed mediation model of antecedents of COBSBs. As illustrated and argued subsequently, we hypothesize that the three dimensions of organizational justice are positively related to each of the three dimensions of COBSBs *indirectly* through their effects on job satisfaction and/or organizational commitment. Although not illustrated, we further hypothesize that procedural justice is more strongly related to each dimension of COBSBs than are distributive or interactional justice because of its stronger relationship with job satisfaction and/or organizational commitment. Finally, we contend that the indirect effects of organizational justice on COBSBs through job satis-

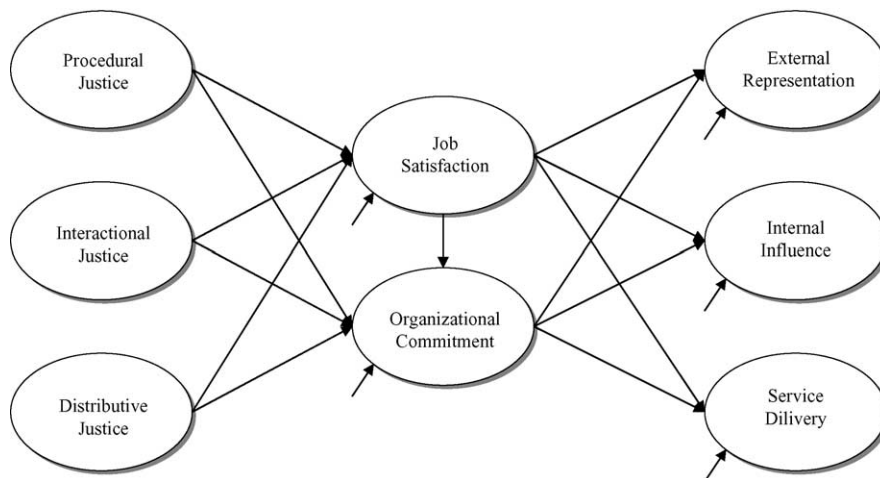


Fig. 1. Complete mediation structural model. Note: Covariances among the three exogenous justice constructs and among the structural error terms of the three endogenous COBSB constructs are not shown for clarity of the model.

faction and/or organizational commitment will be stronger for external representation and internal influence than for service delivery.

Theoretical foundation

Social exchange provides the theoretical foundation for our hypotheses. Social exchange theory contends that employee actions and attitudes toward the organization exist on a continuum anchored by contractual (alternatively, *economic*) exchange on the one end and social exchange on the other (Blau 1964, 1968; Organ 1988b, 1990). Although both types of exchange rely on the expectation that exchange relations will be rewarding, contractual exchange relationships rely on formal agreements to specify and reward well-defined role expectations that are devoid of any social or relational meaning whereas social exchange relationships are characterized by diffuse and open-ended role expectations that rely on reciprocity and norms of *justice* as their foundation (Blau 1964, 1968; Organ 1990).

Hypotheses

We contend that perceptions of organizational justice lead employees to define their relationship with the organization in open-ended social exchange terms as reflected in job satisfaction and organizational commitment, which then lead employees to engage in COBSBs (Blau 1964, 1968; Netemeyer et al. 1997). More specifically, we expect that organizational justice perceptions will be related to COBSBs only to the extent that they lead to the development of social exchange bonds with the organization in the form of job satisfaction and/or organizational commitment as illustrated in Fig. 1.

Theoretically, Blau (1964, 1968), argued that norms of justice and reciprocity were only starting mechanisms for social exchange. Continued exchange of social gestures in the form of prosocial behaviors such as COBSBs, he argued, depends on an individual's satisfaction with prior exchanges and on his/her commitment to the relationship that develops over time. Similarly, Organ (1990, 1988a, 1988b) contended that the reason that organizational justice perceptions should be related to a variety of discretionary employee behaviors is *because* (un)fairness leads to the development (deterioration) of a perceived social exchange relationship between the employee and the organization, as reflected in global exchange evaluations such as job satisfaction and organizational commitment.

As argued by Blau (1964, 1968), repeated social exchange gestures by an employee depend upon the favorableness of his/her evaluation of the intrinsic and extrinsic rewards of the relationship. This would explain why job satisfaction, which reflects an employee's evaluation of the extrinsic and intrinsic rewards received from the firm, has been found to be positively related to prosocial organizational behaviors like OCBs (cf. MacKenzie et al. 1998; Netemeyer et al. 1997; Organ & Ryan 1995), and would suggest that it should also

be related to other forms of prosocial organizational behavior like COBSBs (Bettencourt & Brown 2003). Further, as Blau (1964, 1968) argued, repeated social exchange gestures by an employee depend upon his/her commitment to a social exchange relationship with the organization. This would explain why organizational commitment, which reflects a psychological attachment between an employee and the firm and an employee's belief that the relationship extends beyond contractual obligations (Mowday, Porter, & Steers 1982), has been found to be positively related to prosocial organizational behaviors like OCBs (MacKenzie et al. 1998; O'Reilly & Chatman 1986) and customer-directed effort and behaviors (Bettencourt & Brown 2003; Masterson, 2001). (The fact that the justice dimensions have been shown to lead to the development of a social exchange relationship with the firm in the form of job satisfaction and organizational commitment reinforces our mediation hypothesis [cf. Aryee, Budhwar, & Chen 2002; Colquitt et al. 2001; McFarlin & Sweeney 1992; Wayne, Tetrick, Shore, & Bommer 2002].)

Although other social exchange constructs might be considered as possible mediators of the relationships among organizational justice and COBSBs (e.g., trust, perceived organizational support), we focus exclusively on job satisfaction and organizational commitment for several reasons. First, as discussed, the social bonds of job satisfaction and organizational commitment are implicit in Blau's (1964, 1968) conceptual discussion of social exchange from which many scholars (e.g., Menguc 2000; Netemeyer et al. 1997) have subsequently drawn their theoretical rationale for a relationship between justice and prosocial organizational behaviors. Second, because of this solid conceptual foundation, job satisfaction and organizational commitment (along with justice) are the most widely studied attitudinal antecedents of prosocial organizational behaviors (cf. Organ & Ryan 1995; Podsakoff et al. 2000). Third, both trust and perceived organizational support might be considered alternative social exchange initiators that lead to the development of the social exchange bonds of job satisfaction and organizational commitment (cf. Aryee et al. 2002; Wayne et al. 2002). However, because trust and organizational support constructs are conceptually very similar to procedural and interactional justice perceptions, respectively, and because empirical research confirms very high correlations among these constructs (cf. Aryee et al. 2002; Wayne et al. 2002), reflecting possible discriminant validity problems, we do not include them in our theoretical model. Finally, our research focuses on the mediating effects of *both* job satisfaction and organizational commitment, not only because there is reason to believe that each of them individually might mediate the effects of justice on COBSBs, but also because they are known to be related to each other. Job satisfaction is generally believed to cause organizational commitment in part because it is more specific, less stable and more rapidly formed, and the empirical evidence overwhelmingly supports this view (cf. Brown & Peterson 1993; Williams & Hazer 1986). This suggests that the mediating effects of these two constructs will be in-

tertained, and Fig. 1 illustrates this expectation. Thus, we contend that any empirical relationships among the justice and COBSB dimensions will be indirect via job satisfaction and/or organizational commitment. This discussion leads to the following hypotheses:

H1A. Procedural justice will be positively related to external representation due to its effects on job satisfaction and/or organizational commitment.

H1B. Procedural justice will be positively related to internal influence due to its effects on job satisfaction and/or organizational commitment.

H1C. Procedural justice will be positively related to service delivery due to its effects on job satisfaction and/or organizational commitment.

H2A. Interactional justice will be positively related to external representation due to its effects on job satisfaction and/or organizational commitment.

H2B. Interactional justice will be positively related to internal influence due to its effects on job satisfaction and/or organizational commitment.

H2C. Interactional justice will be positively related to service delivery due to its effects on job satisfaction and/or organizational commitment.

H3A. Distributive justice will be positively related to external representation due to its effects on job satisfaction and/or organizational commitment.

H3B. Distributive justice will be positively related to internal influence due to its effects on job satisfaction and/or organizational commitment.

H3C. Distributive justice will be positively related to service delivery due to its effects on job satisfaction and/or organizational commitment.

Although all three justice dimensions are expected to be positively related to COBSBs indirectly through job satisfaction and/or organizational commitment, we further hypothesize that procedural justice will be more strongly related to COBSBs *because of* its stronger relationships with job satisfaction and/or organizational commitment. Because we have already argued that the effects of the justice constructs on COBSBs will be mediated by job satisfaction and/or organizational commitment, it follows that any differential strength of effects of procedural justice to COBSBs will also be mediated. As discussed subsequently, both theory and empirical research support the expectation that procedural justice (in comparison to distributive and interactional justice) should be more strongly related to both (1) social exchange attitudes such as job satisfaction and organizational commitment

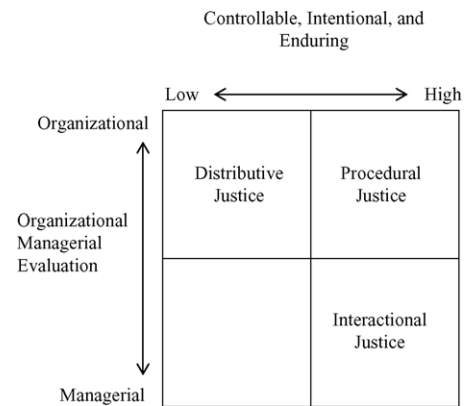


Fig. 2. Theoretical distinctions among the organizational justice dimensions.

and (2) prosocial behaviors such as COBSBs, supporting the hypothesized pattern of mediation effects across the justice constructs.

As Fig. 2 illustrates, there are two important distinctions among the justice dimensions that impact the extent to which they are likely to be related to job satisfaction and organizational commitment (and therefore COBSBs indirectly). First, the justice dimensions differ in the extent to which they are viewed as controllable, intentional, and enduring, with the process justice evaluations theoretically argued to be higher on this dimension (Folger & Cropanzano 1998; Tyler & Lind 1992). Utne and Kidd (1980) argued that *both* attitudes and behaviors are more likely to be affected when organizational justice evaluations are seen as a result of something controllable, intentional, and enduring. Second, the justice dimensions differ in the extent to which they reflect fairness evaluations of *organizational* rewards and processes versus *managerial* actions, with procedural justice and distributive justice being more organizational in focus (Bies & Moag 1986; Folger & Cropanzano 1998). Theoretically, this is an important distinction because we have argued that COBSBs reflect the quality of social exchange bonds *with the organization* and our use of job satisfaction and organizational commitment as social exchange mediators is consistent with this perspective. Empirical evidence that reduced performance of prosocial behaviors precedes organizational withdrawal (i.e., turnover) reinforces this perspective (cf. MacKenzie et al. 1998).

Based on the distinctions in Fig. 2, we argue that procedural justice (in comparison to distributive and interactional justice) will be more strongly related to COBSBs as mediated by job satisfaction and/or organizational commitment. First, fair *organizational* processes are especially likely to lead to the development of a social exchange relationship (whether in attitudes or behavior) with the organization because they are more likely to be viewed as under the *control* (i.e., discretion) *of the organization* (Folger & Cropanzano 1998; Masterson, Kyle, Goldman, & Taylor 2000). Second, because outcomes are more difficult to assess and attribute to a single source than procedures (that is, the accountability for [un]fair rewards is

relatively uncertain), procedural justice is more likely to be used as a source of inference concerning organizational *intent* and caring than distributive justice (Folger & Cropanzano 1998; Tyler & Lind 1992), which will likely be reflected in social exchange evaluations of the job and organization. Further, although the interpersonal interactions that form interactional justice evaluations are highly controllable and intentional, they are a more likely source of inferences concerning *managerial* intent and caring than *organizational* intent and caring (cf. Bies & Moag 1986; Masterson et al. 2000). Finally, procedural justice gives employees confidence in the value of future open-ended interactions with the organization given their more *enduring* nature in comparison to either distributive or interactional justice (Lind & Tyler 1988). Thus, procedural justice is especially relevant to global evaluations of the job and organization such as job satisfaction and organizational commitment (cf. Colquitt et al. 2001; Lind & Tyler 1988; McFarlin & Sweeney 1992). Results of a recent meta-analysis of the organizational justice literature by Colquitt et al. (2001) provide evidence in support of our theoretical reasoning.

We do not hypothesize differential strength of mediation effects for interactional versus distributive justice to COBSBs. Although interactional justice evaluations are likely to be viewed as more highly controllable and intentional than distributive justice evaluations, they reflect an evaluation of managerial fairness whereas distributive justice evaluations reflect the perceived fairness of rewards provided by the organization. Thus, it is not possible to hypothesize whether the mediated paths from interactional or distributive justice to COBSBs will be similar or different from one another. Based on this discussion, we offer the following hypotheses.

H4A. The indirect effect of procedural justice on external representation (mediated by job satisfaction and/or organizational commitment) will be stronger than the indirect effect of distributive justice on external representation.

H4B. The indirect effect of procedural justice on internal influence (mediated by job satisfaction and/or organizational commitment) will be stronger than the indirect effect of distributive justice on internal influence.

H4C. The indirect effect of procedural justice on service delivery (mediated by job satisfaction and/or organizational commitment) will be stronger than the indirect effect of distributive justice on service delivery.

H5A. The indirect effect of procedural justice on external representation (mediated by job satisfaction and/or organizational commitment) will be stronger than the indirect effect of interactional justice on external representation.

H5B. The indirect effect of procedural justice on internal influence (mediated by job satisfaction and/or organizational

commitment) will be stronger than the indirect effect of interactional justice on internal influence.

H5C. The indirect effect of procedural justice on service delivery (mediated by job satisfaction and/or organizational commitment) will be stronger than the indirect effect of interactional justice on service delivery.

Finally, we hypothesize that the indirect effects of organizational justice perceptions on external representation and internal influence behaviors will be stronger than their indirect effects on service delivery behaviors. Consistent with the preceding discussion, we expect that the differential strength of relationships among organizational justice perceptions and distinct dimensions of COBSBs will be mediated by job satisfaction and/or organizational commitment. Social exchange theory provides the basis for expecting both that (1) justice evaluations will be more strongly related to more discretionary forms of COBSBs and (2) the reason for such differential strength of relationships is because justice perceptions lead to the development of a social exchange relationship in the form of job satisfaction and/or organizational commitment.

First, as Organ (1990, 1988a, 1988b) contended over a decade ago, on the continuum from more to less discretionary behaviors, it is the more discretionary behaviors that are likely to be offered as a relationship becomes defined in social exchange terms and also likely to be withheld as a relationship becomes defined in more contractual exchange terms. As previously discussed, organizational justice evaluations provide a critical foundation for the development or deterioration of a social exchange relationship (cf. Folger & Cropanzano 1998; Lind & Tyler 1988). With complementary reasoning, psychological contract theorists argue that *injustice* resulting from a company not meeting an employee's expectations motivates the employee to redefine his/her relationship with the firm from social exchange to one of a strictly contractual nature (i.e., voluntary contributions and discretionary effort are severely curtailed; cf. Robinson, Kraatz, & Rousseau 1994). In support of Organ's social exchange reasoning, a recent study by Tepper et al. (2001) found that the relationship between procedural justice and OCBs was stronger among employees who defined OCBs as more extra-role (i.e., more discretionary).

In the organizational context we study, service delivery behaviors are included in FSE job descriptions, performance evaluation forms, and training documents, making them relatively less discretionary than external representation and internal influence behaviors (Organ 1988a). Further, service delivery behaviors are the most visible of the three types of COBSBs, making them less likely to be withheld in the face of injustice (cf. Organ 1988b). As such, we propose that procedural, interactional, and distributive justice will be more strongly related to external representation and internal influence behaviors due to the relatively discretionary nature of these two forms of COBSBs in comparison to service delivery behaviors.

Second, social exchange theory also provides the theoretical foundation to hypothesize that the differential relationships from organizational justice to external representation and internal influence behaviors will be mediated by job satisfaction and organizational commitment. In keeping with social exchange theory, organizational commitment and job satisfaction are also likely to have stronger relationships with more discretionary forms of COBSBs because these forms of COBSBs are more likely to be viewed as social exchange gestures and, therefore, as more appropriate forms of reciprocation (Blau 1964, 1968; Organ, 1988a, 1988b, 1990). This accounts for why a meta-analysis by Organ and Ryan (1995) revealed a stronger relationship between job satisfaction and OCBs than previous meta-analytic studies had identified between job satisfaction and traditional measures of employee performance. We might also expect organizational commitment to be more strongly related to external representation and internal influence behaviors because they are more clearly intended to benefit the organization rather than specific customers (cf. Masterson et al. 2000).

Thus, prior research suggests that organizational justice perceptions may be more strongly related to external representation and internal influence COBSBs due to their more extra-role nature, and it suggests that any differential effects will be mediated by job satisfaction and/or organizational commitment. Based on this discussion, we offer the following hypotheses.

H1D. The indirect effect of procedural justice on external representation (mediated by job satisfaction and/or organizational commitment) will be stronger than the indirect effect of procedural justice on service delivery.

H1E. The indirect effect of procedural justice on internal influence (mediated by job satisfaction and/or organizational commitment) will be stronger than the indirect effect of procedural justice on service delivery.

H2D. The indirect effect of interactional justice on external representation (mediated by job satisfaction and/or organizational commitment) will be stronger than the indirect effect of interactional justice on service delivery.

H2E. The indirect effect of interactional justice on internal influence (mediated by job satisfaction and/or organizational commitment) will be stronger than the indirect effect of interactional justice on service delivery.

H3D. The indirect effect of distributive justice on external representation (mediated by job satisfaction and/or organizational commitment) will be stronger than the indirect effect of distributive justice on service delivery.

H3E. The indirect effect of distributive justice on internal influence (mediated by job satisfaction and/or organizational commitment) will be stronger than the indirect effect of distributive justice on service delivery.

Research methodology

Sample and procedure

A sample of FSEs of a major, multi-state retail bank was used to test the hypotheses. Retail banking employees tend to be young, low paid, predominantly female, and have low average organizational tenure, and, as such, they are typical of customer service employees of many companies (cf. Singh 2000). Further, FSEs in retail banking have responsibilities and work in a job environment that is similar to other customer service positions. They satisfy customers' needs primarily on a transaction basis, fulfill customer requests for product information, and work within a closely supervised work environment that is remote from corporate offices.

Materials for the study were distributed in packets to branch managers who were then responsible for: (a) distributing individual packets containing a survey, an introductory letter assuring confidentiality, and a postage-paid return envelope to all nonmanagement customer service employees in each branch, and (b) responding to a manager survey asking them to rate COBSBs of each of their individual customer service employees. We took several steps to ensure that the employee packets were not distributed selectively by managers, including providing written instructions to branch managers on how to introduce the study and distribute the packets to employees at a branch meeting. Managers were also requested to provide surveys even to employees who were ill or on vacation during the branch meeting.

The employee survey contained measures of organizational justice, job satisfaction and organizational commitment along with self-report measures of the COBSBs. The manager survey contained measures of the COBSBs of each FSE. In order to link the information from these two sources, employees were asked to write in their names on their surveys, and managers were asked to write the name of the FSE being evaluated on each survey that they completed.

To improve our ability to accurately capture the COBSB constructs, we combined data from two independent rating sources—self-ratings and manager ratings. Both self- and manager ratings have their advantages and disadvantages. Although some research suggests that self-ratings are least biased (Scullen, Mount, & Goff 2000), other research shows that common method variance attributable to sources such as consistency, acquiescence, and positive affectivity can bias results considerably when only self-ratings are used (Podsakoff, MacKenzie, Podsakoff, & Lee 2003). Due to potential common method bias, Podsakoff et al. (2003) recommend gathering predictor and criterion variables from separate rating sources whenever possible. However, use of only manager ratings of COBSBs would have been ill-advised in this research due to the nature of these behaviors. Managers are limited in their knowledge of the extent to which an employee engages in these behaviors, because some instances of

COBSBs may not occur in the presence of the manager or any other branch employees. For example, the manager may have some knowledge of the extent to which an employee is a vocal advocate to outsiders of the organization's image, goods, and services (i.e., external representation) through observations in the workplace and the manager's own contact with customers and other people in the community, but that knowledge is not complete. The service employee is really the only person with complete knowledge, even though she/he may be biased when communicating that information to others. This may also be true to some degree for even an internally directed behavior like internal influence. Further, manager ratings are subject to their own set of biases, including liking, halo, and leniency.

Due to the potential for bias in each rating source, the COBSB measures were administered to both the FSEs and their managers, and the average of these responses on an item by item basis was used to represent the three COBSB constructs in the hypothesis tests. Averaging across multiple raters avoids confounds in method and trait variance. As such, it is preferred to modeling the rating sources separately because it places focus on the construct of interest rather than idiosyncratic rating source perspective or bias. As shown by Scullen et al. (2000) in a major empirical comparison of methods for assessing job performance, convergence across self- and supervisor ratings is often modest due primarily to idiosyncratic error variance in each rating source. However, rather than precluding the averaging of distinct performance ratings, Scullen et al. (2000, p. 967) argued, based on generalizability theory, that "the larger the error components are, the greater is the advantage of using multiple raters." Averaging distinct ratings reduces error variance while "effectively increas[ing] the proportion of true variance" (Scullen et al. 2000, p. 967).

In total, 656 customer service employees were surveyed across 40 branches, representing an entire region of the bank. Completed surveys were received from 344 customer service employees for a response rate of 52 percent. Of the employee responses, it was possible to match 281 with a manager rating of COBSBs. Thus, the matched response rate was 43 percent. We compared the responses of the matched and unmatched employees and found that there were no differences on any of the variables examined in this study.

Approximately 83 percent of the customer service employee sample was female. The median age was 25. The majority of the sample (55 percent) reported "some college" as their highest level of education. The median length of employment was 24 months. A check for nonresponse bias in which the date in which a survey was received by the researchers was regressed upon each of the model variables (e.g., job satisfaction) and selected demographic variables (e.g., tenure, age) produced a significant overall model ($p < .05$) that revealed that later respondents were younger, more highly educated, and had longer company tenure. However, the significant demographic variables explained just four percent of the variance in the date variable.

Measures

Organizational justice

We measured procedural and interactional justice using scales developed by Moorman (1991). The *procedural justice* measure consisted of eight items that reflect employee opinions that decisions about employees are made with consistency, opportunity for appeal, complete information, and representation of all parties. The *interactional justice* measure consisted of ten items that reflect employee opinions that their managers treat them with respect, without bias, and in a sensitive and honest manner when making decisions that affect them. Both of these scales have been shown to possess adequate psychometric properties in prior empirical research (e.g., Moorman 1991; Niehoff & Moorman 1993). We measured *distributive justice* using five items from Price and Mueller's (1986) distributive justice measure that were adapted to focus on the perceived fairness of compensation outcomes, as requested by executives of the cooperating organization. The distributive justice items ask employees to indicate how fairly they are compensated given their experience, effort, stresses, responsibilities, and education and training. Prior empirical research has demonstrated that this measure possesses adequate psychometric properties (Price & Mueller 1986), including high internal consistency among items (cf. Moorman 1991), and this scale has been previously used in the marketing literature (e.g., Netemeyer et al. 1997). Cronbach alphas for the procedural, interactional, and distributive justice measures were .94, .96, and .95, respectively.

Job satisfaction

We measured job satisfaction using the Minnesota Satisfaction Questionnaire (Weiss, Davis, England, & Lofquist 1967), which consists of twenty positively worded items measuring extrinsic (seven items), intrinsic (eleven items), and global (two items) job satisfaction. This multi-dimensional measure has been shown to possess good psychometric properties (Weiss et al., 1967) and has been widely used in the field of marketing (e.g., Brown & Peterson 1993). Cronbach alpha for the job satisfaction measure was .89.

Organizational commitment

We measured organizational commitment using a six-item version of the scale developed by Mowday et al. (1982). Mowday et al.'s complete scale taps behavioral and affective commitment to an organization. This scale (and modifications of it) has been used frequently in prior marketing research (cf. MacKenzie et al., 1998), and found to possess adequate psychometric properties. The six items used in this research were selected to reflect only affective commitment of the employee to the organization because this is thought to be the part of organizational commitment that drives prosocial behavior. A factor analysis indicated that these items were unidimensional and had a Cronbach alpha of .85.

COBSBs

We developed the COBSB measures based on their conceptual definitions and prior research involving the measurement of related prosocial behavior and/or service quality constructs (e.g., Parasuraman et al. 1988; Van Dyne, Graham, & Dienesch 1994). We also conducted group interviews with branch managers of the cooperating organization to confirm the value of COBSBs in this firm and to identify relevant behaviors for each COBSB dimension. Managers were encouraged to identify FSE behaviors either during interactions with customers or behind-the-scenes “that contribute to the ability of [XYZ] to provide exceptional customer service.” Exemplar behaviors from these interviews are reflected in the COBSB items.

External representation was measured using a four-item scale designed to tap the extent to which an employee is a vocal advocate to outsiders of the organization’s image, goods, and services. *Internal influence* was measured with a four-item scale intended to capture the extent to which a person takes individual initiative in communicating to the firm and co-workers about ways to improve service delivery by the organization, co-workers, and oneself. *Service delivery* was measured with a five-item scale that reflects the extent to which the employee serves customers in a conscientious, responsive, flexible, and courteous manner. Cronbach alphas for external representation, internal influence, and service delivery were .90, .94, and .91, respectively. The item wording and additional information concerning the psychometric properties of these scales is provided in Tables 1 and 2 and will be discussed in the next section.

Results

Model specification

The model shown in Fig. 1 was tested with the matched sample of FSEs using AMOS 4.0 (Arbuckle & Wothke 1999). In specifying the structural model, the three justice constructs and the three COBSB constructs were each represented by latent constructs with multiple, reflective indicators. Job satisfaction and organizational commitment were each represented by a single scale score. This was done for several reasons: (a) this is the conventional way these widely used constructs have been empirically represented in the research literature; (b) the MSQ is multi-dimensional; and (c) the total number of measured variables (62) is very large. An important disadvantage of representing these constructs with scales scores is that this ignores measurement error. We compensated for this by fixing the measurement error terms for these two constructs at $(1 - \alpha)$ times the variance of their individual scale scores (e.g., Jöreskog & Sörbom 1982). The scale of measurement for the latent constructs was set by constraining the variance for each exogenous construct and the variance for each structural error term for endogenous constructs to be equal to one.

Assessment of construct reliability and validity

The first step in the analysis was to test the hypothesized measurement relationships and evaluate the reliability and discriminant validity of the constructs. To do this, an eight-construct confirmatory factor model was estimated using the measure covariances as input. Overall, the confirmatory factor model fit the data very well. The chi-square (df) was 1099.50 (633), the comparative fit index (CFI) was .954, and the root mean squared error approximation (RMSEA) was .051. These goodness-of-fit indices were selected because Monte Carlo simulations by Hu and Bentler (1999) have shown that using a combination of indices such as CFI and RMSEA achieves a good balance between Type I and Type II error rates when assessing model fit. According to their simulations, a CFI greater than or equal to .95 and an RMSEA less than or equal to .06 are indicative of a good fitting model and these requirements were met by the hypothesized confirmatory factor model. In addition, as shown in Table 1, the hypothesized factor loadings were all statistically significant at the .01 level, and the completely standardized factor loadings were all quite high and well above the recommended level of .50.

Table 2 reports Cronbach alpha internal consistency reliabilities, average shared variance estimates, and latent construct intercorrelations. As indicated in Table 2, the Cronbach alpha reliability estimates were all well above Nunnally’s (1978) recommended level of .70. Fornell and Larcker’s (1981) index of the average amount of variance each latent factor accounted for in its indicators ($\rho_{vc(\eta)}$) was well above the recommended level of .50 for all of the constructs. Evidence of discriminant validity is provided by the fact that all of the construct intercorrelations were significantly ($p < .05$) less than 1.00; and the variance shared by any two constructs (i.e., the square of their intercorrelation) was always less than the $\rho_{vc(\eta)}$ ’s for the constructs. Thus, taken together, the α s, $\rho_{vc(\eta)}$ s, and tests of the construct intercorrelations, provided strong evidence of the convergent and discriminant validity of the constructs.¹

Because all of the data was obtained at least partially from FSEs, common method variance (cf. Podsakoff et al. 2003) provides a potential rival explanation for the observed pattern of correlations among constructs. Thus, we refit the confirmatory factor model with the addition of a first-order method factor. This extra factor was defined as loading on all of the indicators of the multiply measured latent constructs, and thus captures any additional systematic method variance common

¹ We also estimated a confirmatory measurement model of the COBSB ratings with each rating source modeled separately. The chi-square (df) was 611.89 (282), CFI was .943, and RMSEA was .065. The loadings were all highly significant (minimum t -value > 10.0), the standardized loadings were all quite large ($> .50$), and the average amount of variance each latent factor accounted for in its indicators was well above the recommended level of .50 for all three COBSB constructs for each rating source. These results suggest that the COBSB measures for each rating source are quite good.

Table 1
Means, standard deviations, and standardized loadings for the measures

Measures	Mean	Standard deviation	Standardized estimate
Procedural justice (when decisions about employees are made . . .)			
The concerns of all persons affected by the decisions are heard	3.61	1.69	.82
Requests for clarification and additional information about the decisions are allowed	4.44	1.48	.76
All the sides affected by the decisions are represented	4.06	1.57	.87
The decisions are applied with consistency to all the parties affected	4.25	1.49	.75
Accurate information is collected for making the decisions	4.40	1.43	.84
Complete information is collected for making the decisions	4.38	1.42	.85
Opportunities are provided to appeal or challenge the decisions	4.00	1.54	.81
Useful feedback about the decisions and their implementation is provided	4.26	1.50	.86
Interactional justice (when decisions are made about me, my managers . . .)			
Consider my viewpoint	5.06	1.51	.79
Are able to suppress personal biases	5.10	1.40	.66
provide me with timely feedback about decisions and their implications	5.09	1.40	.76
Treat me with kindness and consideration	5.77	1.29	.86
Show concern for my rights as an employee	5.55	1.39	.92
Take steps to deal with me in a truthful manner	5.68	1.33	.88
Treat me with respect and dignity	5.78	1.32	.89
Are sensitive to my personal needs	5.51	1.53	.86
Offer adequate justification for their decisions	5.28	1.48	.83
Clearly explain their decisions to me	5.33	1.56	.84
Distributive justice			
I am fairly compensated considering the responsibilities that I have	4.06	1.87	.92
I am fairly compensated taking into account the amount of education and training that I have	4.04	1.83	.88
I am fairly compensated in view of the amount of experience that I have	3.99	1.89	.86
I am fairly compensated for the amount of effort that I put forth	3.84	1.92	.92
I am fairly compensated for the stresses and strains of my job	3.67	1.85	.83
Job Satisfaction (20 item MSQ scale score) ^a	3.66	.57	.94
Organizational Commitment (6 item scale score) ^b	4.98	1.12	.92
External representation (slightly reworded for employee self-report items)			
Tells outsiders this is a great place to work	4.69	1.22	.76
Generates favorable goodwill for XYZ	5.12	.96	.83
Says good things about XYZ to others	5.09	.96	.93
Encourages friends and family to use XYZ's products and services	5.18	1.09	.83
Internal influence (slightly reworded for employee self-report items)			
Makes constructive suggestions for service improvement	4.55	1.17	.87
Contributes many ideas for customer promotions and communications	4.02	1.27	.92
Shares creative solutions to customer problems with other team members	4.44	1.18	.92
Encourages co-workers to contribute ideas and suggestions for service improvement	4.07	1.23	.84
Service delivery (slightly reworded for employee self-report items)			
Follows customer service guidelines with extreme care	5.73	.83	.80
Follows up in a timely manner to customer requests and problems	5.74	.81	.77
Regardless of circumstances, exceptionally courteous and respectful to customers	6.01	.81	.73
Follows through in a conscientious manner on promises to customers	5.76	.81	.85
Takes time to understand customer needs on an individual basis	5.72	.79	.90

Note. All loadings are significant ($p < .01$). The goodness of fit indices were: $\chi^2 (df) = 1099.50 (633)$, CFI = .95, RMSEA = .05.

^a Employees were asked to rate their level of satisfaction with each of the following 20 aspects of their job: Being able to keep busy all the time; The chance to work alone on the job; The chance to do different things from time to time; The chance to be "somebody" in the community; The way my managers handle their employees; The competence of my managers in making decisions; Being able to do things that don't go against my conscience; The way my job provides for steady employment; The chance to do things for other people; The chance to tell people what to do; The chance to do something that makes use of my abilities; The way company policies are put into practice; My pay and benefits; The chances for advancement on this job; The freedom to use my own judgment; The chance to try my own methods of doing the job; The working conditions; The way my co-workers get along with each other; The praise I get for doing a good job; The feeling of accomplishment I get from the job.

^b The six organizational commitment items are: I am willing to put forth a great deal of effort beyond that normally expected in order to help XYZ be successful; I would accept almost any type of job assignment in order to keep working for XYZ; I find that my values and XYZ's values are very similar; XYZ really inspires the best in me in the way of job performance; I really care about the fate of XYZ; For me, XYZ is the best of all possible companies for which to work.

Table 2
Latent construct intercorrelations and reliability estimates

	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
1. Procedural justice	(.68, .94)	.67	.51	.71	.58	.48	.22	.39
2. Interactional justice	.61	(.69, .96)	.38	.66	.47	.40	.21	.46
3. Distributive justice	.54	.31	(.78, .95)	.58	.37	.32	.07*	.23
4. Job satisfaction	.70	.65	.56	(-, .89)	.69	.51	.24	.39
5. Organizational commitment	.59	.45	.39	.69	(-, .85)	.65	.37	.34
6. External representation	.43	.41	.24	.49	.61	(.70, .90)	.54	.69
7. Internal influence	.07*	.24	-.12*	.17	.26	.54	(.79, .94)	.45
8. Service delivery	.10*	.40	-.11*	.22	.14	.59	.62	(.66, .91)

Note. Subdiagonal entries are the latent construct intercorrelations not corrected for common method variance. Entries above the diagonal are the latent construct intercorrelations corrected for common method variance. Nonsignificant ($p > .05$) correlations are indicated by an asterisk (*). The first entry on the diagonal is the estimate of the average variance extracted ($\rho_{vc(\eta)}$) from the measurement model without a method factor and the second entry on the diagonal is the Cronbach alpha (α) internal consistency reliability.

to these measures (e.g., common rater bias, social desirability).

Overall, the goodness-of-fit indices ($\chi^2 = 976.31$ with 597 df , CFI = .962, RMSEA = .048) for this model suggested that it fit the data significantly better than the measurement model without the method factor, due to the fact that the method factor was significantly related to 28 of the self-report items. Of importance, the results indicated that: (a) the addition of the method factor did not cause *any* of the hypothesized measurement loadings to become nonsignificant and (b) the hypothesized factor loadings were consistently much bigger (e.g., three or four times bigger) than the method factor loadings. Still, because common method variance can have unknown effects on structural relationships among constructs,

estimation of the structural models for testing the hypotheses included a method factor. Latent construct intercorrelations corrected for method variance are also provided in Table 2.

Estimation of structural models

The next step in the analysis was to estimate the complete mediation structural model shown in Fig. 1. The overall fit of this model was good. The chi-square (df) was 986.94 (606), CFI was .962, and RMSEA was .047. The structural estimates of this model are shown in Table 3. As shown, although some individual path estimates of Fig. 1 are not significant, each of the justice constructs is related to each of the three COBSB di-

Table 3
Standardized estimates of the structural relationships

Structural relationships	Complete mediation model ^a	Saturated model ^b	Trimmed model ^c
Procedural justice → job satisfaction	.33**	.35**	.35**
Interactional justice → job satisfaction	.36**	.32**	.32**
Distributive justice → job satisfaction	.25**	.28**	.28**
Procedural justice → organizational commitment	.24**	.22*	.23**
Interactional justice → organizational commitment	-.06	-.06	—
Distributive justice → organizational commitment	-.07	-.07	—
Job satisfaction → organizational commitment	.61**	.62**	.54**
Job satisfaction → external representation	.15	.00	—
Job satisfaction → internal influence	-.02	-.04	—
Job satisfaction → service delivery	.38**	.04	—
Organizational commitment → external representation	.54**	.54**	.62**
Organizational commitment → internal influence	.40**	.38**	.39**
Organizational commitment → service delivery	.09	.10	—
Procedural justice → external representation	—	.10	—
Procedural justice → internal influence	—	.02	—
Procedural justice → service delivery	—	.08	—
Interactional justice → external representation	—	.06	—
Interactional justice → internal influence	—	.07	—
Interactional justice → service delivery	—	.33*	.38**
Distributive justice → external representation	—	.04	—
Distributive justice → internal influence	—	-.09	—
Distributive justice → service delivery	—	.00	—

^a χ^2 (df) = 986.94 (606), CFI = .962, RMSEA = .047.

^b χ^2 (df) = 976.31 (597), CFI = .962, RMSEA = .048.

^c χ^2 (df) = 990.58 (611), CFI = .962, RMSEA = .047.

* $p < .05$.

** $p < .01$.

Table 4

Indirect and direct effects of organizational justice on customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors

Hypothesized indirect relationships	Standardized estimates	Unstandardized estimates	Z-value	Conclusions	
Indirect effect of procedural justice on external representation	.26	.33 ^a	4.92	Complete mediation	H1A supported
Indirect effect of interactional justice on external representation	.11	.14 ^b	2.95	Complete mediation	H2A supported
Indirect effect of distributive justice on external representation	.09	.12 ^b	3.87	Complete mediation	H3A supported
Indirect effect of procedural justice on internal influence	.16	.18 ^c	2.56	Complete mediation	H1B supported
Indirect effect of interactional justice on internal influence	.07	.07 ^c	2.41	Complete mediation	H2B supported
Indirect effect of distributive justice on internal influence	.06	.06 ^c	2.66	Complete mediation	H3B supported
Indirect effect of procedural justice on service delivery	–	–	–	No mediation	H1C <i>not</i> supported
Indirect effect of interactional justice on service delivery	–	–	–	No mediation	H2C <i>not</i> supported
Indirect effect of distributive justice on service delivery	–	–	–	No mediation	H3C <i>not</i> supported
Direct effect of interactional justice on service delivery	.38	.41	5.44	Direct effect	–

Note. Estimates with common superscripts are *not* significantly different ($p < .05$) from each other using one-tail directional tests. The indirect effect of procedural justice on internal influence is significantly different from the indirect effect of distributive justice on internal influence at $p < .10$.

mensions indirectly via job satisfaction and/or organizational commitment as hypothesized.

Because mediation requires that the indirect relationships are significant even in the presence of the nine direct structural relationships among the three justice constructs and the three COBSB constructs (cf. [Kenny, Kashy, & Bolger 1998](#)), we next estimated a saturated structural model with these nine paths added to the model shown in [Fig. 1](#). The chi-square fit for this model (df) was 976.31 (597), CFI was .962, and RMSEA was .048. A comparison of the chi-square fit between the complete mediation model of [Fig. 1](#) and the saturated structural model indicates that, taken together, the nine additional paths do *not* significantly improve the fit of the full mediation model ($\chi^2_{DIFF} [df=9] = 10.63; p > .10$). However, it is apparent from review of the structural path estimates of [Table 3](#) that mediation is not supported among the justice constructs and service delivery in the presence of the nine direct paths because neither job satisfaction nor organizational commitment has a significant direct effect on service delivery in the saturated structural model. In fact, it appears that the relationship between job satisfaction and service delivery is spurious and based on their common relationship with interactional justice. Thus, a trimmed structural model was estimated with the nonsignificant paths of the saturated structural model removed.

The chi-square fit for the trimmed model (df) was 990.58 (611), CFI was .962, and RMSEA was .047. A comparison of the various goodness-of-fit indices between the trimmed and saturated structural models indicates that the trimmed model provides an equally good fit to the data ($\chi^2_{DIFF} [df=14] = 14.27; p > .10$). Therefore, the indirect path estimates from the trimmed structural model provide the basis for testing the hypotheses.^{2,3}

² The addition of role conflict and role ambiguity as covariates to each of the five endogenous constructs in our complete mediation and trimmed structural models does not affect either the pattern or significance of any of the direct or indirect path estimates.

³ The trimmed structural model was also investigated with each rating source individually. For FSE ratings, the chi-square (df) was 1161.61 (647), CFI was .943, and RMSEA was .053. For manager ratings (MGR), the

Tests of the hypothesized relationships among the constructs

To test the hypotheses, the indirect effects of the organizational justice constructs on the COBSBs must be tested. As shown in [Table 4](#), the hypothesized indirect effects of the justice constructs on external representation and internal influence were all significant, thus supporting H1A ($z = 4.92, p < .001$), H2A ($z = 2.95, p < .01$), H3A ($z = 3.87, p < .001$), H1B ($z = 2.56, p < .05$), H2B ($z = 2.41, p < .05$), and H3B ($z = 2.66, p < .01$). However, because the direct relationships from both job satisfaction and organizational commitment to service delivery were *not* significant in the trimmed structural model, the indirect effects of the justice constructs on service delivery (H1C, H2C, and H3C) were *not* supported by the data. Instead, a direct effect of interactional justice on service delivery was observed ($z = 5.44, p < .001$).

Hypotheses H4A, H4B, H4C, H5A, H5B, and H5C involve predictions about the relative magnitudes of the indirect effects of the organizational justice constructs on the COBSBs. These predictions were tested using the method recommended by [Cohen and Cohen \(1983\)](#) for testing differences between partial regression coefficients from the same sample. Hypotheses H4A and H5A predicted, respectively, that the indirect effect of procedural justice on external representation ($\beta_{unstd} = .33$) would be greater than the indirect effect of distributive justice on external representation ($\beta_{unstd} = .12$) and the indirect effect of interactional justice on external

chi-square (df) was 1066.99 (647), CFI was .960, and RMSEA was .048. The standardized path estimates are: procedural justice $\rightarrow$ job satisfaction (FSE: $\beta = .34; p < .01$; MGR: $\beta = .34; p < .01$); interactional justice $\rightarrow$ job satisfaction (FSE: $\beta = .36; p < .01$; MGR: $\beta = .35; p < .01$); distributive justice $\rightarrow$ job satisfaction (FSE: $\beta = .26; p < .01$; MGR: $\beta = .27; p < .01$); procedural justice $\rightarrow$ organizational commitment (FSE: $\beta = .23; p < .01$; MGR: $\beta = .22; p < .01$); job satisfaction $\rightarrow$ organizational commitment (FSE: $\beta = .54; p < .01$; MGR: $\beta = .54; p < .01$); organizational commitment $\rightarrow$ external representation (FSE: $\beta = .71; p < .01$; MGR: $\beta = .29; p < .01$); organizational commitment $\rightarrow$ internal influence (FSE: $\beta = .40; p < .01$; MGR: $\beta = .06; p > .10$); interactional justice $\rightarrow$ service delivery (FSE: $\beta = .40; p < .01$; MGR: $\beta = .16; p < .01$). Addition of a method factor does not affect the results.

representation ($\beta_{\text{unstd}} = .14$). Using one-tail comparisons because of the conservative nature of these tests, both of these differences were significant consistent with the hypotheses ($z = 2.65, p < .01$; $z = 2.07, p < .05$). H4B and H5B predicted, respectively, that the indirect effect of procedural justice on internal influence ($\beta_{\text{unstd}} = .18$) would be greater than the indirect effect of distributive justice on internal influence ($\beta_{\text{unstd}} = .06$) and the indirect effect of interactional justice on internal influence ($\beta_{\text{unstd}} = .07$). Although both of these differences are in the direction hypothesized, only the difference between the indirect effects of procedural justice and distributive justice is significant ($z = 1.45, p < .10$), offering support for H4B, but not H5B. Finally, H4C and H5C predicted, respectively, that the indirect effects of procedural justice on service delivery would be greater than the indirect effects of distributive justice or interactional justice on service delivery, but these hypotheses were not supported by the findings due to the fact that there were no indirect effects of the organizational justice constructs on service delivery.

The final set of hypotheses involved predictions about the relative magnitudes of the indirect effects of a specific form of organizational justice on each of the three different forms of COBSB. It was expected that the indirect effects of each justice construct on external representation and internal influence would be stronger than the corresponding indirect effect on service delivery. The findings were consistent with H1D and H1E because the indirect effects of procedural justice on external representation ($\beta_{\text{unstd}} = .33, p < .001$) and internal influence ($\beta_{\text{unstd}} = .18, p < .05$) were both significant, but the indirect effect of procedural justice on service delivery was not. The same pattern of support was found for H3D and H3E. The indirect effects of distributive justice on external representation ($\beta_{\text{unstd}} = .12, p < .001$) and internal influence ($\beta_{\text{unstd}} = .06, p < .01$) were both significant, but the indirect effect of distributive justice on service delivery was not. The extent to which the findings support the predictions about the relative magnitudes of the effects of interactional justice on the three forms of COBSB (H2D and H2E) is more difficult to judge. On the one hand, the indirect effects of interactional justice on external representation ($\beta_{\text{unstd}} = .14, p < .01$) and internal influence ($\beta_{\text{unstd}} = .07, p < .05$) were both significant and the indirect effect of interactional justice on service delivery was not. On the other hand, interactional justice was found to have a direct effect on service delivery ($\beta_{\text{unstd}} = .41, p < .001$) that was stronger than its indirect effects on the other COBSBs. Thus, it must be concluded that the overall pattern of findings fails to support H2D and H2E.

Discussion

Consistent with social exchange reasoning, the results provide evidence that all three forms of organizational justice have significant, unique effects on COBSBs through job satisfaction and organizational commitment. As hypothesized, they also show that each of the relationships among the justice

dimensions and external representation and internal influence behaviors are fully mediated by job satisfaction and organizational commitment. Past research has offered social exchange theory as the theoretical rationale for why justice evaluations are positively related to extra-role behaviors. However, few studies have explicitly considered the psychological mechanisms through which justice influences prosocial behaviors. Our results demonstrate that social exchange theory does indeed provide a solid theoretical foundation for understanding the influence of justice evaluations on COBSBs, especially external representation and internal influence behaviors. It also offers complementary findings to prior marketing studies of OCBs that indicate that job satisfaction and organizational commitment are among the immediate drivers of a variety of important prosocial behaviors (cf. MacKenzie et al. 1998; Netemeyer et al., 1997).

Prior research investigating the effects of justice evaluations on prosocial organizational behaviors such as OCBs has also rarely investigated the simultaneous influence of all three theoretically distinct forms of organizational justice (cf. Masterson et al. 2000; Menguc 2000; Moorman et al. 1998; Netemeyer et al. 1997; Niehoff & Moorman 1993). When all three forms of organizational justice have been studied simultaneously, researchers have not found all three to be uniquely related to OCBs (cf. Masterson 2001; Moorman 1991). However, our research suggests that this may stem from the absence of consideration of both job satisfaction and organizational commitment as mediators of the justice to prosocial behaviors relationship. Only the relationship from interactional justice to service delivery was found to be direct.

Further, consistent with our social exchange predictions, the results demonstrated that the indirect effects of procedural justice on external representation and internal influence behaviors through job satisfaction and organizational commitment were generally stronger than the indirect effects of distributive and interactional justice on these behaviors. Further, the direct path from interactional justice to service delivery reflects the only effect of the justice dimensions on service delivery behaviors. Taken together, these results demonstrate that procedural and/or interactional justice are relatively more important drivers of all three forms of COBSBs we studied in comparison to distributive justice. Past investigations of the impact of justice evaluations on prosocial behaviors such as OCBs have often only included a single organizational justice dimension so they were unable to test for the possibility of differential strength of paths from distinct justice dimensions to prosocial behaviors (cf. Menguc 2000; Moorman et al. 1998; Netemeyer et al. 1997; Niehoff & Moorman 1993).

Finally, consistent with social exchange theory, our findings provided support for significant indirect relationships from procedural and distributive justice to external representation and internal influence behaviors, the more extra-role forms of COBSBs, whereas the indirect path relationships from procedural and distributive justice to service delivery behaviors were not significant. These results demonstrate the usefulness of future research offering theoretically de-

rived predictions concerning the differential strength of antecedents on distinct dimensions of COBSBs. Among other differences among the behaviors, we argued that they differ in terms of the extent to which they are performed at the discretion of the employee and in terms of the immediate target of the behavior.

The hypotheses that were not supported by our empirical study largely derive from the effects of adding of one significant path to our proposed model. Specifically, we added a direct significant path from interactional justice to service delivery behaviors, and this added path caused the significant path from job satisfaction to service delivery behaviors to become nonsignificant. Although unexpected, the nonsignificant paths from job satisfaction and organizational commitment to service delivery behaviors are consistent with social exchange theory. As we argued, service delivery behaviors are the least discretionary form of COBSB and, as such, should be the least strongly related to social exchange attitudes such as organizational commitment and job satisfaction. Thus, our hypotheses anticipated weaker paths from the social exchange attitudes to service delivery behaviors. However, we did not expect that these paths would be nonsignificant.

The strength of the direct path from interactional justice to service delivery behaviors in comparison to the indirect effects of interactional justice on either of the other COBSBs was also unexpected. We offer two possible explanations for this finding. First, it is possible that this direct path reflects a role modeling effect as FSEs gain confidence in their ability to serve customers through repeated observation of their manager's favorable treatment of themselves. Such a role modeling effect would be more likely for service delivery behaviors due to their greater similarity with fair interpersonal leadership behaviors, and it would not be expected that such an effect would be mediated by job satisfaction or organizational commitment. Second, the relatively in-role nature of service delivery in comparison to external representation and internal influence may also offer an explanation for the strength of this direct effect. Tyler (1990) and Tyler and Lind (1992) argued that individual willingness to comply with organizational policies and directives (i.e., perform role-prescribed behaviors) is primarily a function of individual attitudes regarding the legitimacy of rules and authority in the firm. Legitimacy of managerial authority is reflected in interactional justice because legitimate authorities are nonarbitrary, consistent, unambiguous, reasonable, and moral. Thus, the direct path from interactional justice to service delivery may reflect the importance of legitimate managerial authority in motivating these behaviors. Future research should consider these and other possibilities.

Future research

Although we found overall support for our social exchange predictions, we do not contend that social exchange theory provides the only explanation of COBSBs. We have con-

tended, for example, that a social exchange relationship between the FSE and the organization serves as a form of informal control that aligns an employee's behavior with organizational interests. Another important form of informal control in a service context that has been shown to be positively related to customer perceptions of service quality is the service climate of the organization or work group (Schneider, White, & Paul 1998). If FSEs believe that customer-oriented initiative is valued by their organization, then we can expect that service climate perceptions will be positively related to COBSBs.

Recent research by Donovan, Brown, and Mowen (2004) suggests that it would also be worthwhile to consider individual customer orientation as an antecedent of COBSBs. Further, their research suggests that it would be worthwhile to investigate the role of job satisfaction and organizational commitment as mediators of any effect of customer orientation on COBSBs. Although research on the personality antecedents of citizenship behaviors has revealed relatively weak relationships (cf. Organ & Ryan 1995), surface traits such as customer orientation may be good predictors of COBSBs because there is a close fit with the behaviors being predicted.

Another interesting avenue to pursue would be to investigate the role of burnout as an antecedent of COBSBs. Singh (2000) has demonstrated that burnout tendencies partially mediate relationships among role stressors and commitment and relationships among role stressors and performance quality of FSEs. Interestingly, distinct dimensions of burnout (i.e., burnout-customer versus burnout-management) and distinct dimensions of role ambiguity (i.e., role ambiguity-customer vs. role ambiguity-company) exhibited a differential pattern of relationships with performance quality. Thus, it would also be interesting for future research to consider the differential pattern of relationships that might emerge among distinct burnout and role ambiguity dimensions and distinct COBSB dimensions.

Limitations

A balanced discussion of our findings must also include consideration of research limitations. First, our findings are based on a single sample of FSEs working for a single firm, and evidence of the generalizability of the results will require further studies with different samples and firms. In particular, our FSE sample was predominantly female and this may affect the generalizability of our results to the extent that gender may moderate some of the relationships we identified. Still, the generalizability of our results to other FSE samples and service contexts should be less of a concern given that our sample characteristics are quite similar to those of prior research among FSEs (cf. Singh 2000). Second, although we investigated a structural model of relationships among variables, our research design was cross-sectional. We can only conclude that our model is a feasible explanation of the observed relationships in the data. The direction of paths in our model relies on prior research. Third, our

study only considered two constructs as social exchange mediators of the effects on organizational justice on COBSBs. Although conceptual and empirical literature justifies the focus on job satisfaction and organizational commitment, it is possible that inclusion of other social exchange mediators may have changed the results—especially with regard to the direct effect of interactional justice on service delivery behaviors.

Managerial implications

The literature and business practice speak extensively about the critical importance of firms developing and implementing a customer orientation. Our research demonstrates for managers the relevance of social exchange relationships in developing such an orientation among customer service employees. As such, it offers a complementary approach to more formal, control-oriented perspectives. In this social exchange context, management must develop and maintain two forms of exchange, between the customer service employee and the supervisor and between the employee and the organization.

The social exchange relationship appears especially important for motivating the more extra-role forms of customer-oriented behavior. These actions include employees taking individual initiative in communications with the firm and co-workers to improve service delivery and employees being vocal advocates to outsiders of the organization's image, goods and services. While a control-oriented management approach may be workable in mandating role-prescribed service behaviors, there are limitations to this approach in encouraging the broader range of customer-oriented behaviors we studied. Even in tightly controlled service contexts, FSEs possess considerable discretion in terms of the customer-oriented behaviors they choose to provide or withhold, and these behaviors rely on a social exchange relationship.

Our research should encourage managers to foster a workplace environment focused on justice to encourage social exchange attitudes among customer service representatives that produce customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors. Our results reveal that management should devote greater relative emphasis to procedural (processes) justice elements to signal the importance of a social exchange relationship with the employee and the importance of the employee and his/her contributions to the organization. Further, because our research demonstrates that job satisfaction and organizational commitment play a key mediating role between distributive and procedural justice evaluations and customer-oriented behaviors, it shows that any steps that management takes to increase employee job satisfaction and/or organizational commitment should lead to increases in the more extra-role customer-oriented behaviors among customer service employees. Finally, our study reveals the central importance of legitimate managerial authority as reflected in fair interactions between FSEs and their immediate managers for motivating exceptional service de-

livery behaviors in remote service contexts such as retail banking.

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